GLASSHOUSE

PRESIDENTIAL PAWAR?

Going by the several rounds of meetings among Opposition leaders, you would think they are ready with a united alliance against the ruling BJP for the 2024 Lok Sabha election. But the real motive behind these parleys seems to be finding a common candidate for the July presidential election. Sources in the Opposition camp claim Nationalist Congress Party patriarch Sharad Pawar has expressed an interest. In the past three months, two chief ministers—West Bengal's Mamata Banerjee and Telangana's K. Chandrashekar Rao—have met Pawar in Mumbai. The expectation is that the BJP's numbers in Uttar Pradesh will go down, helping the non-BJP forces put up a tougher contest against the saffron party's candidate. However, an unscheduled meeting between Union minister Piyush Goyal and Pawar at the latter's Mumbai home on the day of Lata Mangeshkar's funeral has confounded observers. Pawar's unpredictability, after all, is legendary.



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

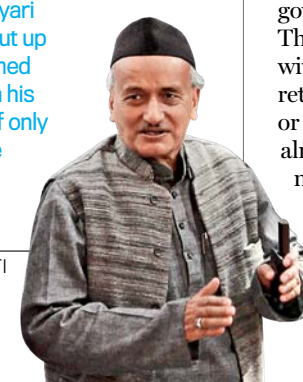
Federal Friction



Telangana chief minister **K. Chandrashekar Rao** dispensed with the convention of the governor addressing the legislature at the start of the budget session, which fell on March 7 this year, also the first session of 2022. His logic? The previous session of the legislative assembly, which ended on October 8, was not prorogued. KCR was also peeved that governor Tamilisai Sounderarajan did not rely entirely on the government's text in her Republic Day address. Moreover, KCR, along with other states, is bracing for a pitched battle for federal rights against the Union government.

SwaRaj Bhavans

Maharashtra governor **Bhagat Singh Koshyari** has mooted the idea to rename the several British-era halls in Raj Bhavans across the country after Indian saints. To begin with, he has suggested that 'Darbar Hall' in Mumbai be renamed 'Samarth Hall' after Samarth Ramdas, the 17th-century saint in Maharashtra. Koshyari also has a plan to put up photographs of armed freedom-fighters in his official residence. If only the Union and state governments clear his brainwave.



PTI

–Kaushik Deka with Amarnath K. Menon, Kiran D. Tare, Romita Datta and Rohit Parihar



Page Turner

Realising perhaps that the pen is mightier than the sword, Trinamool Congress strongman **Anubrata Mondal** has written an autobiography, titled *Khela Hobe*. The memoir traces his transition from the unassuming boy Keshto to the hard-hitting politician who is alleged to have won several political battles by flexing his muscles. Also known for his unparliamentary language, laced often with the choicest invective, the book comes as a refreshing change. Instead of dripping poison, the pen has produced some insight.

OFF-COLOUR



Budgets are one time opposition parties can corner ruling governments, but in Rajasthan the BJP ended up scoring a self-goal. First, state BJP chief **Satish Poonia** compared the budget with a "dark-complexioned bride who is made to look good with make-up at a beauty parlour". Then, he apologised for the sexist comment but tried to get even by announcing that he and other BJP MLAs will return the iPhones the Ashok Gehlot government had gifted all MLAs. These days, local media is agog with how many BJP MLAs have returned the iPhone, willingly or otherwise, how many have already started using it and how many have gifted it to their wives or children.